



LACK OF FREE SERVICES

The first one is free

The past few years have seen a dramatic decrease in the number and the quality of free services being offered. Big names like Yahoo! are now charging money for solutions that were not-so-long-ago free, even as they discontinue other free features in their services. Taking candy from a baby wouldn't hurt so much if the sweet wasn't offered in the first place. The fact is that we have tasted blood and nothing else comes close—the only comfort is the services that are left.

For e-mail services there is always Yahoo!, MSN and Indiatimes to turn to. But if you are looking for something a little more feature-filled, then we have two such services for you—the first one is OutGun.com (www.outgun.com). It offers a cool 10 MB of inbox space along with extras such as a calendar, a file manager, a file-sharing feature and a place for all your favourite bookmarks. The other service is MyRealbox (www.myrealbox.com), which too offers a generous 10 MB of space. It also features effective anti-spam and anti-virus capabilities, an address book and a calendar service. The most attractive feature of MyRealbox is its support for Internet protocols such as SMTP, IMAP, POP, LDAP, HTML, SSL and TLS. You can thus receive e-mail from a variety of clients such as Microsoft Outlook/Outlook Express, Netscape Communicator, Qualcomm Eudora, Novell GroupWise and more.

If you want to create your own Web page and share it with the rest of the world for free, then give Brinkster (www.brinkster.com) a try. It's ad-free, supports ASP and Flash, and offers 30 MB of space for your creation. And it makes file syncing a breeze with its Web-based file manager. Or try Crosswinds.Net (www.crosswinds.net), which offers unlimited space and Web-based e-mail, but at the cost of banner ads.

Yahoo! Briefcase is a service worth mentioning for sharing files online. It offers a sufficient, if not a comfortable 30 MB of Web space and if you use its mail service, you can save mail attachments directly to your Briefcase.



INFRASTRUCTURE IN INDIA

Promises and lies

By now, we should've been receiving moving pictures, streaming music and up-to-the-minute news broadcasts over the

Internet—at least in theory. The multimedia heaven that was promised is still far away. So what happened? Blame it on bandwidth or rather, the lack of it. Still damned to surf over modems that offer a piddly 5 to 6 Kbps of download speed, the majority of us are forced to remain content with text and ads that feature animated monkeys. Then there are the backbreaking charges levied by both, the phone company and the ISP. And it's not as if a dial-up service is reliable either—a little drizzle can herald the death of your phone line at worst or a noisy connection (leading to data loss) at best. The so-called 'broadband' services are here, but the affordable ones offer only 30 to 40 Kbps of speed. The ones that offer a decent 1 to 2 Mbps of speed charge an arm and a leg.

If you plan to subscribe to such a service, ask for a trial to ensure that it delivers a speed that you find satisfying. Make sure that you test it at a location as close to your place as possible. If you cannot get a broadband service, then your best bet is a download utility such as FlashGet (www.flashget.com) or GetRight (www.getright.com). Such a utility will not speed up your browsing but will help you download large files and lessen the pain of a dial-up connection.



PEOPLE

Hell is other people

There will always be those who will take advantage of the anonymity of the online world. They are the ones who will write the most destructive virus, just because they can. They will bring down your corporate Web site, just because they fancy it. As a matter of fact, they are the fountainhead from which springs all the Net Nasties. Sadly, there is no escaping them.

And then there are the mischief makers who hang around your favourite online forum, eager to derail and spoil a heated discussion. Known as 'Trolls', they indulge in anti-social activities that range from spamming a fellow forum-user, to posting offensive messages and images. The social nature of the Internet makes running into these pests a very likely event.

What can you do? Absolutely nothing. What you can take solace in is that these form a minority. After all, the most interesting aspect of the online world is the interaction between you and the rest of humanity. Realise that these Trolls do not own the Net and like a bad headache, they too will go away if we ignore them! 

info



Kevin Mitnick, a 37-year-old US resident faced 25 charges for a series of attacks on systems belonging to software makers, ISPs, and educational institutions such as Netcom, Motorola, Nokia, Fujitsu, Sun Microsystems and the University of Southern California

info

FIRST POST!

All these other guys are

LOSERS!



Bringer of Bad News: If you see this posted on a forum, the topic of discussion is already dead, courtesy your friendly neighbourhood forum Troll